



Long Time Away

"AFTER 30 YEARS, it was almost too good to believe."

That was Andy Cohen's reaction to the telephone call from John Quinn, general manager of the Philadelphia Phillies, which put the former Eau Claire Bears manager back in the major leagues as a coach.

"It was in the winter of 1929 that I was traded out of the majors by the New York Giants," Andy reminded a group of friends during his visit here. "Now, after 30 years, I'm back."

Still the friendly, fast-talking, energetic Cohen who guided Eau Claire Bears team in the golden years of 1948-49-50, Andy is looking forward to his job with the last-place Phils.

"John Quinn is a great baseball man. I'm looking forward to the challenge of helping boost a tail-ender up the ladder," Cohen said.

Andy knows that he will be in charge of the Phils' infield and expects to coach first or third base under Manager Eddie Sawyer. Cohen learned his defensive ball under the exacting tutelage of the Giants' John McGraw.

The decision to return to baseball wasn't as easy for Cohen as might be expected. Andy stayed out last season, has a good job in his native El Paso, Texas, and likes to be with his wife and three children.

"But I'm sure I'll never regret giving it one more try," Cohen added.

Although he's managed at Denver, New Orleans and Indianapolis since leaving Eau Claire, Andy has many happy memories of his three seasons at Carson Park.

"One of my greatest thrills in baseball was in the 1949 season when Earl Bass hit the two-run homer in the last of the ninth inning that beat St. Cloud, 2-1, and brought us the pennant on the last day of the season," Cohen recalled.

He added that just as important as Bass' homer was preceding play in which Whitey Ries, the runner on first base, had hustled to break up a double play and kept the Bears' chances alive.

Cohen managed here in the post-war years when baseball attendance was at an all-time peak. His 1948 club finished third and drew 89,971 fans; his 1949 club won the pennant and drew an all-time high of 103,150; and his 1950 club lost the pennant on the last day of the season and drew 85,987.

Another episode of Carson Park days fresh in Cohen's memory was the 1949 game with Fargo-Moorhead in which the Bears were retired with only two outs in one inning. It happened on a confusing play in which Don Steger collided with an umpire and was put out twice.

Asked about some of his former players here, Cohen recalled Karol (Ducky) Kwak, who teamed with Bill Bruton in the 1950 outfield and who had as much or more ability than the Milwaukee outfield star.

"Ducky had everything but the right attitude," Andy said. "I tried to get him for my New Orleans team later, but he dropped out of baseball and is now living in Chicago."

Ries, the Northern League's most valuable player in 1949, is now a scout for the St. Louis Cardinals. Cohen recalled that Whitey had an uncanny ability to hit the ball. He holds the loop record of going 85 straight games without a strikeout.

Harry Hanebrink, who hit 16 homers to lead the Northern League in 1949, may play again under Cohen with Philadelphia. He was with the Phils last season but is now with their Triple A farm club at Buffalo.

Cohen left Eau Claire Saturday noon for Minneapolis, where he played seven years and became an all-time favorite with Miller fans. He'll speak at a baseball dinner there tonight.